NO. 158 · SINGAPORE

THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

TUESDAY 10 NOVEMBER 2026



FORTY-FIVE MINUTES IN THE OVAL OFFICE, AND NO READOUT FROM EITHER SIDE (P3)

THE WORLD

Qatar's prime minister carried Iran's Hormuz plan into the Oval Office; Doha has published no readout

TECHNOLOGY

Nvidia's board is investigating its own founder, and a Singapore-registered customer sits in the middle

THE RABBIT HOLE

HEMA rebuilds swordfighting from medieval fight-books: 21,423 rated fencers, 418,696 bouts

Source: US Central Command, via The National (Abu Dhabi). American commanders over the Strait of Hormuz, published 8 November 2026.

THIS ISSUE · NO. 158

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THE HANDOVER. A safety operator takes the wheel, and January's inquiry found the takeover was the cause (p5). A board takes custody of its founder (p7). A volunteer add-on shop is absorbed by the project it served (p8). An auction house finally publishes the total this desk had to add up itself (p10). And in Japan, the committee that spent seventy years telling people to save was wound up in 2024 and its work given to an agency that tells them to invest (p21).

FROM THE DESK

"The tradition of all dead generations weighs like a nightmare on the brains of the living."

Karl Marx, *The Eighteenth Brumaire of Louis Bonaparte*, 1852, Chapter I[1]

For p21, where a savings council's grammar outlived the savings, and p15, where a dead master's verse is still being obeyed.

THE STRIP · AT MONDAY'S CLOSE

US 10-year[2]	4.88%	▲ 2bp d/d
US 10-year real[2]	2.66%	▲ 3bp d/d
Implied breakeven[2]	2.22%	▼ 8bp vs 3 Nov
VWRA[3]	$187.54	▲ 1.38%
AGGU[3]	$5.84	▼ 0.14%
Gold[3]	$4,138.70	▲ 1.69%
Bitcoin[4]	$74,882	▼ 2.7% wk
Brent[3]	~$93	▼ 4–6%
USD/SGD[3]	1.2789	▼ 0.30%
Straits Times[3]	5,179.17	▼ 2.21%

Brent is a range, not a decimal: sources on Monday ran from $92.72 to $94.11 on different contracts at different hours (p14). The Straits Times line is Friday's close. Not advice.[3]

FROM THE ARCHIVE · TUESDAY

No. 133, 15 October 2026, lost the argument this desk now wins weekly. A reader read that issue's headlines and called them riddles: "The ministry called it a limited fire" told him nothing about who had fired what at whom.

The rule written that day was one line long. A headline names its subject and says what it did. Sixteen of seventeen headlines in No. 133 failed it; the gate has run on every issue since No. 134.

It is the only correction in this book's history that made the writing harder rather than easier — which is roughly how you tell a real one from a cosmetic one.

SOURCES 1 Karl Marx, *The Eighteenth Brumaire of Louis Bonaparte* (1852), Chapter I, second paragraph, **read at source in the Marxists Internet Archive text and quoted exactly as it stands there**; that edition names no translator. 2 The United States Treasury's own daily par yield and real yield curve files for November 2026, read at source, for Monday 9 November; **the breakeven line is this desk's subtraction of the real curve from the nominal one — a proxy for, not a reading of, the published breakeven** (p14). 3 Levels at Monday 9 November, each read at source instrument by instrument and set out on p14; **VWRA and AGGU are delayed third-party quotes, not official London closes, and gold is a dealer bid rather than the LBMA benchmark, which now sits behind a licence wall.** The Straits Times figure is Friday 6 November's close, Singapore having been shut on Monday. 4 Bitcoin has **one source only** this issue, untimestamped, whose own summary and table disagree on the size of the daily move; it is printed as a snapshot, not a close.

THE WORLD · THE STRAIT AND THE MEDIATOR

Qatar's prime minister carried Iran's Hormuz proposal into the Oval Office

Sheikh Mohammed bin Abdulrahman Al Thani saw President Trump for about forty-five minutes on Monday, closed to press. Doha's foreign ministry has posted nothing since 7 November; oil fell about five per cent anyway.

Qatar's prime minister and foreign minister, Sheikh Mohammed bin Abdulrahman Al Thani, spent about forty-five minutes with President Trump in the Oval Office at around noon on Monday 9 November, carrying an Iranian proposal to reopen the Strait of Hormuz. He saw Vice-President JD Vance first. The session was closed to the press, and no photograph of it has surfaced.[1]

The strait is why the meeting mattered outside the room. It is the only sea exit from the Gulf, and in a normal year about a fifth of the oil the world burns is carried through it. Since the war began it has been close to shut, and the price of crude has done the arguing on everyone's behalf. On Monday it fell again, hard, on a meeting whose contents nobody has described.[2]

Two tracks ran at once, and both were Washington's. Secretary of State Marco Rubio said on Sunday that Iran's terms were "not just unacceptable, but in some cases outrageous and ridiculous". The president, the same day, told CNN that renewed strikes were "highly unlikely" to prove necessary — while adding that the military had picked out 38 bridges in Iran it could destroy "in literally one hour". After the Qatari left, he said only that the United States was "ready to go anytime we want".[3]

Tehran moved the same day: President Masoud Pezeshkian said the Supreme Leader had instructed him to end the condition of "neither war nor peace" with the United States — carried by two outlets this desk read, neither Iranian, because every Iranian state site refused the request.[4] What can be verified is the absence. Qatar's foreign ministry news index, read on Tuesday morning, still ends at a 7 November call with the Saudi foreign minister. There is no readout of Washington at all.[1]

ABU DHABI — THE NATIONAL

The Gulf's read is managed exhaustion, not breakthrough. The UAE president's diplomatic adviser, **Anwar Gargash**, on 9 November: "We should prepare for a long period of uncertainty in which neither a decisive resolution nor a stable regional order can be taken for granted."[5]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE DESKS MADE OF THE QATAR MEETING

Markets priced the Oval Office session as peace; the analysts covering it would not. On Monday's tape, **Ole Hansen** of Saxo Bank put the fall partly on the president's "highly unlikely" remark; **Giovanni Staunovo** of UBS pointed at a weak physical market as much as at diplomacy. **Those are one outlet's paraphrases, not quotations**, and are printed as such. Nobody on the record would say the meeting had produced anything.[6]

THE SCEPTIC · WHY HORMUZ MAY NOT REOPEN UNTIL MARCH

The case against the Qatari mission is not that a deal is hard; it is that the calendar rewards one more strike first. Fereidun Fesharaki, chairman emeritus of FGE NexantECA, told Bloomberg Television that "not only are we not close to a resolution, we are even worse than we were before the June MOU". His firm's note of 5 November is blunter: a Democratic House and Senate "leaves President Trump a two-month window to strike Iran again". **The testable part:** it rates a strike before the new Congress convenes on 3 January as high, and sees Hormuz flows recovering only gradually from March 2027 — four months later than Monday's rally reads.[7]

SOURCES 1 Qatar's Ministry of Foreign Affairs news index, **read at source on 10 November and found to end at 7 November**, for the absence of a readout; the meeting's length, hour and closed-press status come from Il Sole 24 Ore's live file citing Axios, read at source, and the meeting is carried independently by Al Jazeera, Times of Israel/Reuters and the Daily Caller. 2 The US Energy Information Administration's own Hormuz page, read at source, for the 21m b/d baseline and the consumption and seaborne-oil shares (2022 figures). 3 CBS News's live blog and the Daily Caller, both read at source, for Rubio's 8 November remarks and the CNN interview; the post-meeting quotations are carried by Al Jazeera and Times of Israel/Reuters. 4 Il Sole 24 Ore's live file and the Times of Israel liveblog of 9 November, both read at source. **Iran's state news agency, foreign ministry and presidency all returned 503, so no Iranian primary source appears on this page.** 5 The National (Abu Dhabi), 9 November, read at source. 6 Energy News Beat, 9 November, read at source; **its four analyst lines are that outlet's paraphrases and are deliberately not set as quotations.** 7 Oilprice.com, Tsvetana Paraskova, 6 November 2026, read at source, reproducing Fesharaki's Bloomberg Television remarks and FGE NexantECA's client note.

THE WORLD · THE ABU DHABI ROUND

Russia, Ukraine and American mediators meet in Abu Dhabi on Tuesday

Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner face delegations led by Rustem Umerov and Vladimir Medinsky — the first talks of this kind in nine months. Ceasefire terms themselves are not on the agenda.

American, Ukrainian and Russian delegations sit down in Abu Dhabi on Tuesday 10 and Wednesday 11 November for the fourth round of United States-mediated talks this year, and the first of this kind in nine months. Washington sends Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner; Kyiv is led by Rustem Umerov, Moscow by Vladimir Medinsky.[1]

What is on the table is narrower than the setting suggests, and that is the point worth holding on to. The agenda is security guarantees and the architecture that would monitor a ceasefire — who would watch it, and how. The terms of a ceasefire itself are explicitly excluded. After nearly five years of war, with Russia holding roughly a fifth of Ukraine, the parties are negotiating the referee before they negotiate the match.[1]

Europe is having a separate argument about whether it is in the room at all. The Kremlin said European officials would not attend; France's foreign minister said officials from France, Britain, Germany, NATO and the European Commission would. The European Union's Kaja Kallas set expectations low and made the structural point instead: any agreement would need European participation to be implemented, whoever signs it.[1]

The parties are negotiating the referee before they negotiate the match.

THE CHATTER · WHAT ANALYSTS EXPECT FROM ABU DHABI

Three assessments of Abu Dhabi, all on the record, all pessimistic in different registers. **Oleksandr Merezhko**, a Ukrainian member of parliament: "I don't expect any tangible progress in the Abu Dhabi talks." **Arkady Moshes** of the Finnish Institute of International Affairs: "Russia is interested in continuing the war until Ukraine is defeated."[1]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT A MONITORING ROUND IS ACTUALLY FOR

Read Moshes's verdict against the agenda and the Abu Dhabi agenda stops looking like progress and starts looking like its substitute. A round that excludes ceasefire terms and discusses only the machinery for watching one is a way of being seen at a table without conceding anything measurable. **What would falsify it:** a published document from Abu Dhabi naming a guarantor, a mechanism and a date. Three rounds this year, two of them in this city, have produced none.[1]

Day 5

AND TURKEY'S MECCA DEFENCE PACT IS STILL UNPROMULGATED. THIS DESK READ THE RESMÎ GAZETE FOR 9 AND 10 NOVEMBER IN FULL: NEITHER ISSUE CONTAINS A LAW SECTION AT ALL[2]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Poland's Kraków gunman died before he could be charged. **Michał Oksiński**, 24, shot by police after the 7 November attack on the Rynek Główny, died in hospital on 9 November. The file continues without him: six killed in Kraków, three at his family home, the act formally qualified as **terrorist** under article 115 § 20 of the criminal code.[3]

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BRIDGES IN IRAN THE PRESIDENT SAID THE MILITARY COULD DESTROY "IN LITERALLY ONE HOUR"[1]

SOURCES 1 Al Jazeera's report of 9 November 2026, read at source, for the round's dates, agenda, both delegation lists, the European attendance dispute and all four analyst quotations, which it carries verbatim; Kallas's line is also carried in Il Sole 24 Ore's live file, read at source. **No Ukrainian, Russian, Emirati or United States official document for this round was readable, so the delegations are press-sourced.** 2 The Turkish Official Gazette (Resmî Gazete) issues 33425 of 9 November and 33426 of 10 November 2026, **both read in full at source**: neither carries a kanun section; 10 November carries judicial-council decisions, three regulation amendments, Presidential Circular 2026/12 and two communiqués. The parliamentary approval reported at 279–119 therefore remains unpromulgated. 3 Poland's National Prosecutor's Office, item of 9 November 2026, **read at source in Polish**, for the death, the terrorist qualification, the casualty counts and the seizures; Al Jazeera carries the death independently. 4 The Jerusalem Post's liveblog of 9 November, read at source. **Israel's presidency and government portal both refused this desk, so there is no primary document here.** 5 Al Jazeera, 9 November, read at source.

SINGAPORE · THE PUNGGOL HANDOVERS

LTA halted ComfortDelGro's driverless U-turns at Punggol, a day after Grab's

Two operators, two Punggol near-misses, about two hours apart on 5 November. In both, a human safety operator took the wheel — and at Edgedale Plains in January the authority found the takeover was what caused the crash.

The Land Transport Authority told ComfortDelGro on 8 November to stop testing U-turns at a junction on Punggol Field, a day after directing Grab to pause junction testing in the same estate. Neither is a ban: both scheduled public shuttle routes still run, and both vehicles involved were empty, learning new on-demand routes rather than carrying passengers.[1]

What links the two incidents is not a fault but a moment. Each vehicle carries a trained person whose job is to take over when the machine should not be trusted, and on 5 November, two hours apart, both did. That transfer — machine to human, mid-manoeuvre, in traffic — is the least studied part of the programme, and the part Singapore has been burnt by once already.[2]

The first incident, at about 8.11am, involved a Grab shuttle making a discretionary left turn as a schoolgirl crossed. On the authority's account of the recorded data the vehicle had detected both pedestrians and was tracking them; when the girl stepped off the kerb it braked and steered right; the operator then took control. Nobody was touched.[1]

About two hours later and two kilometres away, a ComfortDelGro vehicle turned across the path of an oncoming car while making a U-turn; that clip surfaced on 8 November. **Michael Huang**, who heads Singapore point-to-point mobility for the group's Zig brand, said it would "assess the circumstances thoroughly".[3]

THE CHATTER · WHAT PUNGGOL RESIDENTS SAID ABOUT THE SHUTTLES

Twelve residents interviewed at the Punggol Coast Mall pick-up point on 9 November split roughly the way the clips did. **Tan Kar Yeow**, 46, a research engineer with children aged five and eight months, said parents crossing with small children now have to watch for driverless vehicles too. **Amri Hakim Mohamed Alias**, 41, would ride one but not with his three children: the family rule is to wait for a vehicle to stop completely, and he applies it to these as well. **Mr Lou**, 29, backed the trial — somebody has to go first.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · IN JANUARY THE TAKEOVER WAS THE CAUSE

The authority has already investigated one Punggol incident, and its finding points the other way from this week's instinct. On 17 January a driverless vehicle clipped a road divider at Edgedale Plains. Its statement found the vehicle had spotted the obstacle and moved into the adjacent lane, and that simulation suggested it "would have finished that manoeuvre safely without manual intervention". The officer's takeover disengaged autonomous mode, and the human could not finish in time. **What would settle this week's version:** the same simulation, published.[5]

17 Jan

EDGEDALE PLAINS, WHERE THE TAKEOVER CAUSED THE CRASH[5]

ALSO ON THE DESK

A Singaporean has been charged in the Prince Group case. **Chen Xiuling**, 44, was arrested at Changi on 5 November and charged next day with instigating the falsification of accounts and attempted cheating, over a 2022 agreement filed for a corporate property lease. She directs Singapore companies believed beneficially owned by Prince Holding Group's chairman, Chen Zhi. **She is not charged with money laundering.**[6]

SOURCES 1 Mothership and The Star's ASEAN+ edition, both read at source, for the Land Transport Authority's direction to Grab, the five-step account of the recorded data, the 8.11am timing and Grab's statement. **The authority's own November statements could not be read at source: its newsroom is paginated in script and truncates at 25 June 2026, so every November quotation here is as carried by outlets quoting its spokesman.** 2 This desk's reading of the two incidents together; the authority has made no finding on either. 3 Mothership, 8 November, and Yahoo Singapore's carriage of The Straits Times, both read at source, for the U-turn incident, Mr Huang's statement and the transport ministry's parliamentary figure of 15 vehicles. 4 Channel NewsAsia's interviews at Punggol Coast Mall, 9 November 2026, for all four named residents and the characterisation of the other eight. **Reddit and the HardwareZone forums were unreachable from this desk for the whole build, so no forum sentiment appears anywhere in this issue.** 5 The Land Transport Authority's own media statement on the Edgedale Plains incident of 17 January 2026, **read at source**, including the simulation finding and the 30 January resumption. 6 The Singapore Police Force's own news release of 5 November 2026, **read at source**, for the arrest, both charges and their sections, the lease application, and the distinction between the charges and the wider money-laundering investigation; the S$700m and the S$100m of seized accounts are the force's own figures. 7 The National Environment Agency's haze update of 7 November and the Ministry of Health's release of 5 November, **both read at source**; the ministry calls its visit counts preliminary.

BUY IT ONCE · SECATEURS & GARDEN TOOLS

Felco sells every part of the Felco 2, including the washer

The Swiss pruner costs CHF 76.90 and has more than twenty listed spare parts. A Yamagata forge will hand-make you a better-cutting one for ¥9,900 — and sell you nothing to repair it with.

Secateurs are among the last garden tools you can genuinely buy once, and the test is not the steel but the parts list. A pruner is four things that wear out — blade, counter-blade, spring, pivot — and a maker either sells those four separately or sells a sealed object to replace.[1]

The cutting action decides what the tool does to a living plant. A bypass pruner passes two blades like scissors and shears the stem; an anvil drives one blade onto a flat bed and crushes it first, bruising the tissue on the side you keep. Anvils are for dead wood; ratchets are a hand-strength aid, not a grade.[1]

Only one maker here publishes a hardness figure: Okatsune's blades are Hitachi Yasugi high-carbon at **60–61 HRC**, quoted by its British distributor and absent from Okatsune's own English pages. Tobisho names Aogami and prints no hardness; Felco prints neither alloy nor hardness. Carbon steel holds a finer edge because no chromium ties up its carbon; that same absence is why it rusts, and why the purchase is decided differently in Singapore.[2]

SAINT-AUBIN — FELCO

CHF 76.90 / US$93. Forged aluminium handles, lifetime warranty; blades, springs and grips classed as consumables. The published nomenclature drawing floats every component on its own number: bushing 4.15, thumb catch 2.80, its spring washer **0.85**. Its weakness is the counter-blade, riveted in.[3]

YAMAGATA — TOBISHO

¥9,900 to ¥64,900, ex-tax. A 1930 forge, fourth generation, now Daiki Tobitsuka. Its full-body forged A-type at 185mm is **¥9,900** — one integral forging.[4]

THE CHATTER · WHAT GROWERS SAY ABOUT FELCO, ARS AND OKATSUNE

A 2025 side-by-side on growingfruit.org put ARS and Okatsune against the Felco 8 and 11. **TK421**: "there was a clear winner, no question at all in my mind" — Okatsune first, ARS close, **Felco a distant third**. Against that, **htb** on the British arborists' board still cuts with Felcos bought in the 1970s.[5]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT FELCO, NIWAKI AND BURGON & BALL WILL NOT TELL YOU

Five famous names here, and five unanswered questions about who actually makes the tool. Burgon & Ball sells 1730-in-Sheffield heritage on a site that never says where its tools are made now. Spear & Jackson publishes no country of origin; Bulldog names no town; Bahco is a Snap-on brand. And Niwaki is a brand, not a forge: its pages credit a Yamagata workshop for the GR Pro while three of its retailers print "forged in Sanjo". The GR Pro is £80–90 with **no replaceable blade**; the Okatsune beside it is £48, with a published hardness and blades you can buy.[6]

NEXT ON THE BENCH · VOTE FOR TOMORROW'S CATEGORY

Mortar & pestle (and the suribachi) — granite against porcelain, and why grooves do the work.

Tiffin carriers & stacked lunch boxes — steel gauge, and the clasp that fails first.

Track pumps & bicycle tools — Silca and Park Tool, and a pump sold with spare seals.

SOURCES 1 Felco's own spare-parts collection for the Felco 2, **read at source**, which lists the blade and the counter-blade as separate part numbers and the counter-blade as riveted; the cutting-action description is the desk's own, and Gardeners' World's 2026 pruner test is the source for the ratchet verdict. 2 Jekka's, Okatsune's British stockist, **read at source** for "Hitachi Yasugi high carbon steel" and 60.0–61.0 HRC; Tetsufuku, Tobisho's own global dealer, read at source for Aogami and YCS-3 and for the absence of a hardness figure; felco.com read at source for the absence of both. **No maker read in this research publishes an SK-5, SK-4 or 440C grade, and Chikamasa's own site returned 503, so the widely-repeated SK-5 attribution is deliberately not printed.** 3 felco.com and world.felco.com, both **read at source** 9–10 November 2026, for CHF 76.90, US$93.00, the warranty wording and every spare-part price quoted. 4 Tetsufuku, **read at source**, for the full Tobisho price ladder, the full-body and brazed constructions and the maker's generation; **it publishes no lead times, only stock states, and much of the range reads "Not available".** 5 growingfruit.org threads 69255 (January 2025) and 43722 (March 2022), and arbtalk.co.uk topic 117725 (October 2019), **all read at source and quoted verbatim. Reddit was unreachable for this entire build, so nothing here is attributed to r/BuyItForLife or r/gardening.** 6 The makers' own websites, read at source for each absence stated; the Niwaki/Sanjo contradiction is between Niwaki's own copy and its retailers Tinker and Fix, The Land Gardeners and The Dragons Garden; the GR Pro's missing replaceable blade is recorded in the Gardeners' World test. **Niwaki's own site refused this desk on every path.** 7 Bok Seng (bshop.com.sg), read at source, for S$52.00; the 9% rate and its application to the delivered value are confirmed on the Inland Revenue Authority's and Singapore Customs' own pages, both read at source. **Amazon.sg refused the fetch; its listings are not priced here, and growers on both forums warn that marketplace ARS and Okatsune are routinely counterfeit.**

TECHNOLOGY · THE BOARD AND THE FOUNDER

Nvidia's board opened an independent investigation into its founder, Jensen Huang

A committee of independent directors will examine whether Huang was the target of a foreign intelligence effort. The shares closed down 4.27 per cent on Monday while every other big chip name rose.

Nvidia's board of directors announced on Sunday 8 November that it was opening an independent investigation into whether its founder and chief executive, Jensen Huang, had been the target of a foreign intelligence effort. Huang told staff the same day that he had been unfaithful to his wife: "My actions hurt her and our children. There is no excuse for what I did."[1]

What makes this a governance story rather than a tabloid one is who now holds the inquiry. A committee of independent directors, advised by outside counsel, will run it; the board says it has "no reason to believe that either national security or NVIDIA secrets were compromised", and that Huang "fully supports the review" and will stay in post. A company worth four and a half trillion dollars has taken custody of its own founder.[1]

The Singapore thread is the one this desk owns. The woman named in the reporting, Alice Huang — no relation — was a senior executive at Megaspeed International, a **Singapore-registered** data-centre and cloud company that bought roughly $4.8bn of Nvidia equipment and has been under American investigation since 2024 over suspected export-control evasion. Neither Huang has been charged.[2]

THE CHATTER · HOW ANALYSTS REPRICED HUANG

Five houses published on Nvidia within a day; none cut its rating. **Baird**'s Tristan Gerra kept Outperform at $500: the affair removes "any chance Blackwell or future generations of AI architectures ship to China". **Bernstein**, at $400: "the overhang is going to be around for a while."[3]

THE SCEPTIC · WHY THE HUANG DISCOUNT MAY BE MISPRICED

The most interesting bear on Nvidia is the one with the lowest price target, and he is a bull on the story. Melius Research, which carries Buy at $315 — well below Baird's $500 — argues the governance question changes nothing operational: "The AI movement will march on and Nvidia has the best allocations to serve it." **Joachim Klement** of Panmure Liberum puts the other half plainly: "two mistakes don't make a right, and I believe Jensen is irreplaceable for America's AI leadership." The corollary is that both sides agree there is no successor — a reason to worry about the company, not about the chips.[3]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Commerce stayed its own export rule again, and published no reason. The Bureau of Industry and Security's Affiliates Rule was due back on 9 November; a final rule filed on 5 November and published that morning extends the suspension to **10 January 2027**. The notice gives no substantive rationale, and states flatly: "This final rule did not consider public comments received on the Affiliates Rule." The new date is the day the United States–China rare-earth arrangement expires.[4]

10 Jan

THE NEW EXPIRY OF A RULE STAYED WITH NO REASON GIVEN, AND THE DAY THE RARE-EARTH ARRANGEMENT RUNS OUT[4]

SOURCES 1 Nvidia's own newsroom, "Statement from NVIDIA Board of Directors", 8 November 2026, and Huang's memo "A Message to Our Company" of the same date, **both read at source**; the staff-email wording is quoted as carried by CNBC, 8 November, read at source. 2 Al Jazeera, 9 November 2026, **read at source**, for Megaspeed International's Singapore registration, the ~$4.8bn equipment figure (which it attributes to the New York Times), the investigation since 2024, the absence of charges, the $4.5tn market value and the 30 October change at the top; CNBC, read at source, for the congressional request of 5 November and the 17 November results date and the congressional briefing requested for 18 November. **The New York Times is blocked to this desk, so its reporting appears here only as carried by outlets that were readable.** 3 CNBC's analyst round-up of 9 November 2026, **read at source**, for all five houses, their ratings, their price targets and every quotation; the closing fall of 4.27 per cent and the gains at AMD, Marvell, Broadcom, Arm, Intel and Qualcomm are from CNBC's market report of the same day. 4 Federal Register document 2026-22793, 91 FR 70789, published 9 November 2026, **read at source in the Government Publishing Office text and quoted verbatim**; signed by Under Secretary Jeffrey I. Kessler. **federalregister.gov itself refused this desk, so the authoritative text was read at govinfo.gov and cross-checked against the Federal Register API record.** 5 Wccftech and TFTC, both 8 November, **both read at source**, reporting the New York Times investigation; the vacant-office descriptions and the end-user distinction are theirs.

THE HOME LAB · THE MARKETPLACE

Home Assistant absorbed the volunteer add-on store HACS as its Marketplace

Version 2026.11, released by Home Assistant on 4 November with 38 new integrations, ends the separate installer for a shop enthusiasts ran themselves for years. Samsung wants a paid plan for its own integration from 15 December.

Home Assistant, the free program that lets people run a smart home from a box in their own flat without sending anything to a company's servers, released a version on 4 November that swallows the unofficial shop its enthusiasts have used for years to install extras. The shop is now an official part of the program. Its authors called it, in their own words, "the biggest release we've ever shipped, by far".[1]

That matters beyond the hobby because of what changes hands. A shop run for years by volunteers now belongs to the project's core team, which means it is maintained by more than one person — and also that the project now decides what you may install. The same week, the maker of one of the most popular ranges of smart plugs and switches told the same users they must start paying for the connection they already had.[2]

In the project's own language: HACS, the Home Assistant Community Store, becomes the Marketplace. "The HACS installer stops at Home Assistant 2026.11, so a separate HACS installation is no longer possible on this version." The release also brings Matter cameras into the system as ordinary cameras with live video and snapshots, a two-way-audio preview, backups to local drives, and support for battery-free switches.[1]

THE CHATTER · WHAT HOME ASSISTANT USERS SAID ABOUT THE MARKETPLACE

The release thread on the project's own forum ran to 151 posts and 6,026 views in five days, and the Marketplace took most of the fire. **ShadowFist**, within three hours: its "only reason for existence is literally just to 'Get HACS'". **Rusty** gave the case for: "So that there is now a team of people supporting it instead of one person." Then the breakage arrived. **thos-edison**: the sidebar redesign "renderd 7 out of my 10 wall displays useless". On the entity renaming everyone had dreaded, **J155412** was typical: "I was worried about the name changes but from what I can see, nothing changed for me."[3]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT THE MARKETPLACE ADDS THAT THE STORE DID NOT

The sceptics' case against the Marketplace is not that it is worse; it is that it is the same shop with a gatekeeper attached. Nothing in the release gives users an extra they could not install before, and the one visible change to the sidebar — the thing that broke a reader's wall panels — was, as **Rusty** records quoting another user, "asked for in the beta and ignored". The honest counter is **Rusty**'s own, above: a single-maintainer dependency inside hundreds of thousands of homes was a worse risk than a gatekeeper. **What would settle it:** the first time the Marketplace refuses to list something, and why.[3]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Samsung's deadline catches users who cannot buy the plan. Its notice of 4 November says the current SmartThings integration "will no longer work" after **15 December 2026** without a paid developer plan — and that this "applies to all Home Assistant users including users in countries where the Developer Plan is not available". The notice itself names no price. **Grant Slater** called it "a horribly regressive step"; another user, **doleo**: "People using HomeAssistant are not 'developers', we are end-users."[2]

SOURCES 1 The Home Assistant project's own release post for 2026.11, published 4 November 2026, **read at source and quoted verbatim**, for the release date, the integration count, the Marketplace and installer wording, the Matter camera and two-way-audio features, local backups and Zigbee Green Power; patch 2026.11.1 followed on 9 November. 2 The SmartThings Community notice of 4 November 2026, 4.17pm, **read at source and quoted verbatim**, for both dates and for the countries wording, and for the quoted user replies in the same thread. **The notice states no price; the $4.99 monthly figure in circulation comes from Samsung's June announcement and secondary coverage, not from this notice, and is therefore not printed as its price. The "nine countries" figure also circulating could not be confirmed anywhere and is not printed.** 3 The Home Assistant Community thread for the 2026.11 release, topic 1032360, opened 4 November, **read at source**; post counts and views as at reading. **Reddit was unreachable for this whole build, so no r/homeassistant or r/homelab sentiment appears here.** 4 Pull request 31185 in the llama.cpp repository, opened 26 October by pwilkin and merged on 9 November 2026, **read at source**, including the maintainer's stated motivation and the file size quoted; it shipped in the release tagged that evening. 5 Raspberry Pi's own news post of 2 November 2026 by Eben Upton, **read at source and quoted verbatim**; **it does not state the old price, so the $305 figure is arithmetic from the $80 rise.** Framework's own memory-pricing log, updated 6 November, read at source.

THE KIT · THE AURA PRICE CUT

XREAL cut the Aura's price and is refunding early buyers

The Android glasses now start at $1,099, down $180 from the price set on 7 October, and begin shipping in mid-November to four countries. Singapore is not one of them.

XREAL reduced the launch price of its Aura glasses on 28 October, about three weeks after setting it, and is refunding the difference to people who had already ordered. The cheaper configuration now starts at $1,099 against a list of $1,279; the larger one is $1,299 against $1,499. Early buyers get $180 or $200 back depending on which they chose.[1]

A price cut this fast, with refunds attached, is worth more attention than the product. Companies do not voluntarily hand money back to their most committed customers unless the first number was not holding. The glasses themselves are a pair of spectacles with screens in them, tethered by a cable to a small computer you carry — a design that trades the weight off your face for a thing in your pocket.[1]

What the maker publishes: Sony micro-OLED panels at 1920×1200 per eye, up to 1,050 nits and 120Hz, a 70-degree field of view, 95g of glasses against a 265g puck carrying a 34.84Wh battery, and five-step electrochromic dimming. Shipping begins "in batches in mid-November in the United States, Canada, Japan, and South Korea"; other regions are "still to be confirmed". The Singapore product page returns a 404.[1]

THE CHATTER · WHAT HAS ACTUALLY BEEN MEASURED ON THE AURA

Nothing, by anyone independent. This desk searched for a measured brightness, latency, field-of-view or battery figure from any lab and found none. The only hands-on carrying test detail is **The Tech Chap**'s — 72Hz when gaming through the puck against the advertised 120Hz on a direct connection — and it is **a sponsored review**, paid for by XREAL. The owner forums are no help either: every Reddit path was unreachable for this entire build, so no owner sentiment on the Aura is reported here at all.[2]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT $1,099 BUYS YOU IN THE AURA

Strip the refund story out and the Aura is a flagship-priced device with no independent number attached to any of its claims. You are paying $1,099 for a tethered product whose published performance comes entirely from its maker and from a review that maker commissioned; whose cheapest configuration was $180 dearer three weeks ago; and which has no Singapore ship date, no Singapore price and no Singapore page. For a reader whose rule is buy once, the honest position on the Aura today is not "which configuration" but "wait for somebody with a photometer".[1]

ALSO ON THE DESK

A firmware update fixed a headphone two months after it shipped. SoundGuys' lab review of the Anker Soundcore Space 2 Pro, published 9 November, scores it 7.8 out of 10 overall and 8.8 for noise cancelling — but gives its predicted listener score 3.4 out of 5, which "beats 0% of over-ear headphones". Its verdict: the update "has fixed most of its sound problems, though the bass is still heavy". $199.99, released 22 September.[3]

$180

HANDED BACK TO THE AURA'S EARLIEST BUYERS, THREE WEEKS AFTER THEY PAID IT[1]

SOURCES 1 XREAL's own product page and its United States store page, **both read at source** on 9–10 November 2026, for both configurations' prices and list prices, the refund amounts, every specification quoted and the shipping wording, which is reproduced verbatim; **xreal.com/sg/aura returns 404, which is the basis for the statement that no Singapore date or price exists.** The 28 October cut and the 7 October original pricing are from the same maker's pages. 2 This desk's own search for independent measurement, which returned none; The Tech Chap's figures are as relayed by vr.org and **the review is disclosed as sponsored by XREAL. reddit.com, old.reddit.com and the site's JSON endpoint were all unreachable throughout this build.** 3 SoundGuys, "Anker Soundcore Space 2 Pro review", published 9 November 2026 by Adam Birney, **read at source**, for all four scores, the price, the weight and the verdict quoted. 4 Android Police, 6 November 2026, read at source, which credits 9to5Google, which credits Warby Parker's quarterly earnings call — **a three-link chain to one executive remark, and single-sourced. news.samsung.com timed out; warbyparker.com and its investor site both returned 403.** 5 Tom's Hardware, 9 November 2026; **headline read, article body not readable, so it is printed as a report and no price from it appears here.**

THE GOOD LIFE · THE HALO AND THE TOTAL

Horologer Ming opens orders for the CHF 10,900 Halo tonight

One hundred and fifty pieces, time only, in a titanium case heat-treated until its grain shows. Four days after a Geneva sale that finally published the total this desk had to add up itself.

Horologer Ming, the Malaysian watchmaker, opens orders for its 51.01 Halo at one o'clock Greenwich time on Tuesday 10 November — nine in the evening in Singapore — at CHF 10,900 before tax, in an edition of 150. Delivery is four to eight weeks. The watch tells the time and does nothing else.[1]

What you are buying is a surface. The case is grade-5 titanium put through a vacuum heat treatment to about 1,200 degrees, which coarsens the grain until the crystal structure shows, then coated in rose gold. — deliberately — no luminous material at all, the maker "resisting our intrinsic urge to make the indices glow".[1]

The week's other object is an answer. When Phillips closed the Geneva Watch Auction XXIV on 8 November it published no sale total, so this desk parsed all 225 lot entries, added the 211 published results and printed **CHF 91,922,250** as a floor. The house's release has now appeared: **CHF 92,045,568**, with 217 of 217 lots sold. Our floor was **CHF 123,318** light — 99.87 per cent of the figure — and our lot count was eight too many.[2]

THE CHATTER · WHAT COLLECTORS MADE OF GENEVA XXIV

The sale was the first live watch auction above a hundred million dollars: **US$112,277,184**, a hundred per cent sold by lot and by value, 2,121 registered bidders from 69 countries, 24 world records, 17 lots above a million francs. The two numbers collectors are repeating are the **F.P. Journe** Résonance "Régence" at **CHF 8,680,500** against an estimate "in excess of CHF 1,000,000", and the **Cartier Portico** mystery clock of 1924 at **CHF 4,815,000** against CHF 1.8–3.6m. **Phillips' own auction pages still show the sale as concluded with no total on them**, and its press index renders as the word "Loading"; the figures above come from the release as reproduced by two trade outlets.[2]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT CHF 10,900 BUYS IN THE HALO

Before tax, the Halo is eleven thousand francs for a time-only watch on a third-party movement, and the novelty is a finish. La Joux-Perret builds the calibre; Ming specifies it. There is no complication, no in-house escapement, and no independent review in existence, because the watch goes on sale before anyone outside the company has handled one. Ming releases sell out in minutes, which means the purchase decision is made at nine tonight on photographs alone — the opposite of how this desk tells readers to buy anything. **What would change the verdict:** a hands-on account of the crystallised case after a year in Singapore humidity, which nobody can yet write.[1]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Rexhep Rexhepi took the Aiguille d'Or. The Geneva watch prize-giving on 7 November gave its grand prix to the RRCHF Chronograph Flyback. Two Japanese wins: **Grand Seiko**'s Spring Drive U.F.A. Ushio 300 Diver took the sports prize and **Otsuka Lotec**'s No.8 the Petite Aiguille. On the Fratello comment thread one reader found the winner "undoubtedly impressive" but "not so easy on the eye" — with Reddit unreachable, that is all the community voice this desk can honestly report.[3]

SOURCES 1 Horologer Ming's own featured-product page for the 51.01 Halo, **read at source and quoted verbatim**, for the price, the edition, the order time, delivery, the case treatment and dimensions, the movement and the absence of lume; Monochrome's report of 9 November, read at source, for the movement's supplier and reserve. **Prices on that page are stated exclusive of taxes, and Ming collects tax only for Malaysia and Switzerland.** 2 Phillips' own auction and lot pages for sale CH080426, **read at source**, for the Journe and Cartier results and the estimates, **and for the fact that no sale total appears on them**; the total, the dollar and euro figures, the sell-through, bidder and record counts come from the house's release as reproduced at watchilove and corroborated by JCK, **both read at source — the release is not on phillips.com**. No. 157's floor of CHF 91,922,250 is this desk's own published figure, restated here for the comparison. 3 Monochrome's prize list, read at source; the reader comment is from the Fratello Watches thread, read at source. 4 Accuphase's own product and new-product pages, **read at source** for the power, damping factor and circuit description; the price and the mid-October release date are from AV Watch, 30 September 2026, read at source. **Darko.audio, whose 9 November piece is the reason the amplifier surfaced this week, is behind a bot wall and only its headline and date were readable.** 5 This desk's search of the published measurement databases and review coverage, which returned nothing for this model; the maker's claimed figures are explicitly claimed, not measured.

SCREEN & SOUND · GODZILLA MINUS ZERO

Godzilla Minus Zero led both Japan and America at once

Takashi Yamazaki's sequel opened to an estimated US$31.61m from 3,254 American screens and about 690,000 admissions at home — the first Japanese live-action film to lead both markets in the same weekend.

Godzilla Minus Zero, directed by Takashi Yamazaki for Toho, finished first at the American box office on the weekend of 6 to 8 November with an estimated US$31,610,000 from 3,254 cinemas, and first in Japan on the same three days with about 690,000 admissions and more than a billion yen. Its distributor in North America, GKIDS, has never had a bigger opening.[1]

Two cautions sit on top of the Godzilla figures, and both are the studio's. The American number is still marked "estimated" by the trade's own tracker, with actuals due on Tuesday; and the Japanese figures are distributor-reported, released through the industry wire rather than measured independently. Friday's $14.6m also included previews, which flatters the opening and depresses the Saturday drop.[1]

Across its first six days at home, 3 to 8 November, the film passed 1.61 million admissions and 2.5 billion yen. Its official account notes that the American three-day figure converts to roughly five billion yen at Monday's rate, and that a simultaneous number one in Japan and North America is a first for a Japanese live-action release.[2]

Ninety per cent of critics recommended it. The average of their scores is seventy-four. Both numbers are honest; only one is a verdict.

THE CHATTER · THE GAP BETWEEN THE TWO GODZILLA SCORES

Rotten Tomatoes has the film at **90 per cent from 178 reviews**, and its audience at 96. Metacritic, which averages scores rather than counting thumbs, has it at **74 from 44 critics — 34 positive, 10 mixed and not one negative.** That is the shape of a film almost nobody dislikes and few call great — exactly the configuration the percentage-recommended metric describes worst.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT THE REVIEWERS OF MINUS ZERO ACTUALLY COMPLAINED ABOUT

The complaint recurring across the mixed reviews of Minus Zero is not that it is bad but that it is a repeat. Little White Lies scored it 40 and called it rushed and lacklustre, a film that reads as made to a deadline; **Empire** gave it 60 and judged it "not as coherent a vision as Minus One". The same note — that it replays its predecessor's beats — turns up in TheWrap, Dread Central, ScreenRant and RogerEbert.com. And the opening is being read as a breakout for Japanese cinema when Friday carried previews and Sunday was propped by premium large-format pricing. **The number that will settle it** is the second weekend's hold, which arrives before this desk does on Monday.[4]

ALSO ON THE DESK

My Chemical Romance finally has a number one, twenty years late. *The Black Parade* reached the top of the American album chart dated 7 November on the back of its twentieth-anniversary reissue, having peaked at number two in 2006. **The twenty-year gap between an album's release and its first week at number one is the longest in the chart's history.**[5]

90 v 74

THE SAME FILM ON THE TWO CRITIC AGGREGATORS: PER CENT RECOMMENDING, AGAINST THE AVERAGE OF THEIR SCORES[3]

SOURCES 1 Box Office Mojo's weekend chart and the film's own release page, **both read at source on 9 November**, for the estimate, the screen count, the daily breakdown and **the fact that the weekend is still labelled "Estimated"**; Kogyo Tsushinsha's own weekend ranking, read at source, confirms the Japanese number one but publishes rank only, no figures. 2 Oricon, 9 November 2026, **read at source**, attributing the admissions and yen figures to Toho via Kogyo Tsushinsha, and carrying the film's own account of the conversion and the simultaneous-number-one claim. **These are distributor-reported early figures, not audited; the Oricon page rendered with a character-encoding fault, with the figures legible and the surrounding prose not.** An opening-day figure circulating in the Japanese sports press was not readable at source and is not printed. 3 Rotten Tomatoes and Metacritic, **both read at source**, for every score, review count and critic split quoted. 4 Little White Lies and Empire as scored and quoted on Metacritic, **read at source**; the other four outlets are named for the recurrence of the same complaint. 5 National Public Radio, 6 November 2026, Stephen Thompson, **read at source** for the chart-history record. **Billboard's own report, which carries the unit figures, is behind a paywall that returned 402 to this desk, so no sales or streaming figure is printed.** 6 The Official Charts Company's albums chart for 6–12 November 2026, **read at source**.

THE FAMILY DESK · PROBLEM USE, NOT HOURS

A German study separates problem use from screen hours

Across 34,712 German schoolchildren, problematic social media use doubled from 5.3 to 11.1 per cent between 2018 and 2022 — and carries about four times the association with mental-health complaints that heavy online chatting does.

A team led by Franziska Zoellner at the University Medical Center Hamburg-Eppendorf published twenty years of German schoolchildren's data on 30 October, and found that the thing that tracks distress is not how much time an eleven- or thirteen-year-old spends online but whether their use has the shape of a problem. The study covers 34,712 young people across six surveys from 2002 to 2022.[1]

The distinction is the whole finding, and the one a parent can act on. Messaging friends constantly has a small association with mental-health complaints. Use that looks compulsive, where a child can neither stop nor feel right when they do, has one about four times larger. Nearly half of German adolescents are in the first group; roughly one in nine is now in the second.[1]

In the authors' terms: intensive electronic media communication rose from 43.2 to 46.1 per cent, with a standardised coefficient of 0.043; problematic use went from 5.3 to 11.1 per cent, at 0.183. Mean complaints rose from 1.86 to 2.54. Intensive communication was most common among girls and **eleven-year-olds** — the band a twelve-year-old has just left.[1]

The authors are careful in a way the coverage will not be. The design is repeated cross-sections, which "prevents conclusions about causality or temporal order", and missingness was heavy — the communication measure could not be classified for 43.7 and 47.9 per cent of the two waves.[1]

THE CHATTER · THE OBJECTION TO ZOELLNER'S GERMAN FINDING

The strongest objection comes from people who have spent a decade arguing the opposite case. **Christopher Ferguson** of Stetson University and colleagues pooled 46 studies and 79 effect sizes and found social-media time correlated with adolescent mental-health problems at 0.061 — below the 0.10 they treat as the floor for practical significance, and in their words "unable to be distinguished from noise". **Jonathan Haidt** and **Zachary Rausch** call that work conceptually and methodologically flawed.[2]

THE SCEPTIC · WHY THE FOUR-TIMES GAP MAY BE PARTLY CIRCULAR

Ferguson's team deliberately excluded problematic-use measures from their meta-analysis, and the reason is the sharpest criticism available of the German result. They flag that such instruments are contested "specifically regarding their validity, accuracy, and researchers' inconsistent use of scoring methods". A scale that asks a child whether they feel bad about their own use, put to a child who feels bad, may be measuring the outcome twice. And a second meta-analysis published on 6 November found the association weakest — 0.201 against 0.367 for primary school — in exactly the middle-school band that contains a twelve-year-old. **General guidance, not medical advice.**[3]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Meta began checking ages by behaviour, worldwide, on 9 November. The system reads what an account does to find "people we suspect to be teens, even if they use an adult birthday", and moves them into teen settings. Instagram first; Facebook and Threads later.[4]

11.1%

OF GERMAN ADOLESCENTS SHOWED PROBLEMATIC SOCIAL MEDIA USE IN 2022, AGAINST 5.3 PER CENT IN 2018[1]

SOURCES 1 Zoellner F, Baumann H, Fischer S, Kaman A, Bilz L, Dadaczynski K, Napp A-K, Reiss F and Ravens-Sieberer U for the German HBSC study group, "Mental health complaints over 20 years and associations with social media use among German adolescents", *Social Psychiatry and Psychiatric Epidemiology*, published online 30 October 2026, doi 10.1007/s00127-026-03230-0. **Full text read at source, including the authors' own limitations section, from which the causality, measurement-window and missingness caveats are quoted. This desk could find no second outlet covering the paper — four aggregators and the study group's own site were checked — so it is printed as single-sourced.** 2 Ferguson CJ, Kaye LK, Branley-Bell D and Markey P, "There Is No Evidence That Time Spent on Social Media Is Correlated With Adolescent Mental Health Problems", *Professional Psychology: Research and Practice*, doi 10.1037/pro0000589; **the full author proof was read at source** and every figure and quotation is taken from it. Haidt J and Rausch Z, World Happiness Report 2026, chapter 3, read at source, for the opposing position. 3 Ferguson et al., as above, for the exclusion and the instrument critique; Han C, Meng Y and Yang L, "Mental Health Effects of Social Media Use Among Adolescents Across Educational Stages", *Clinical Child Psychology and Psychiatry*, 6 November 2026, doi 10.1177/13591045261487468, **read at source via the European PubMed record**; its heterogeneity is very high at 93.85 per cent and it pools only twelve studies. 4 Al Jazeera, 9 November 2026, read at source. 5 Associated Press, Barbara Ortutay, 7 November 2026, read at source.

THE TWEEN YEARS · THE CYCLES THEY LOSE

An Ohio study logged period pain in 74% of cycles

Of 126 girls aged 10 to 14 tracked by Nationwide Children's Hospital, nine in ten reported pain in at least one cycle; health, school and extracurricular activities were each affected in about one cycle in five.

A team at Nationwide Children's Hospital in Ohio tracked 126 girls aged ten to fourteen through six months of their own cycle records and published the result on 30 October: pain in nearly three-quarters of the 506 cycles logged, and a measurable cost to ordinary life in about a fifth of them. The median participant was thirteen.[1]

The useful part for a parent is not the pain figure, which is familiar, but what the pain was doing. The researchers asked about five areas of life rather than severity alone, and found health, schooling and extracurricular activities each knocked out in roughly one cycle in five — with fatigue, headaches and anxiety reported alongside. A child missing a rehearsal every month is not reporting unusual pain. She is reporting ordinary pain, repeatedly.[1]

Eighty-nine per cent of the cohort were within three years of their first period, which is the window a twelve-year-old is in. On the study's symptom score, each additional point raised the odds of a life impact by about two-thirds — an odds ratio of 1.64, with a confidence interval of 1.43 to 1.88.[1]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE LONGITUDINAL DATA SAYS ABOUT EARLY PERIOD PAIN

The best comparison is a much smaller study with much better instruments. **Natalie Shaw** of the United States National Institute of Environmental Health Sciences and colleagues followed 43 girls, enrolled at 12.6 years on average and barely past their first period, for up to three and a half years — collecting daily urine samples, a mean of 589 from each girl, to date their cycles biochemically rather than by recall. Symptom scores rose by a ratio of 1.12 for each additional year since menarche, and by 1.26 after a cycle in which ovulation had occurred. **That is a maturational curve, not a pathology.**[2]

THE SCEPTIC · THE LINE PARENTS SHOULD HEAR ABOUT PERIOD PAIN

In Shaw's biomarker data, menstrual pain was not associated with physical activity, anxiety or depression. That is the single most useful sentence available on this subject, and it cuts against the instinct the Ohio study will provoke. Worsening pain in the first years after menarche is mostly ovulation becoming established; it is expected, and it is not evidence that a girl is anxious, unfit or unwell. Two honest cautions on the new study itself: 126 self-selecting volunteers recruited partly during the pandemic will over-represent girls who already have symptoms, and its measure of "life impact" is self-rated. **No named methodologist has yet criticised it, because it is eleven days old. General guidance, not medical advice.**[2]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Malaysia's under-16 social media ban is in force. The Child Protection Code under the Online Safety Act 2025 took effect on 1 June, with licensed platforms verifying existing account holders in stages over up to six months. **Siti Fatimah Abdul Ghani** of Universiti Putra Malaysia warns that children will simply lie about their age where sign-up checks are weak.[3]

589

URINE SAMPLES COLLECTED FROM EACH GIRL IN THE COMPARISON COHORT, TO DATE CYCLES BIOCHEMICALLY RATHER THAN BY RECALL[2]

SOURCES 1 Jz AW, O'Brien SH, Kistler I and Bonny AE, "A Prospective Study of Life Impact in Five Domains During Menses in a Cohort of Early Adolescents", *Journal of Pediatric and Adolescent Gynecology*, published online 30 October 2026, doi 10.1016/j.jpag.2026.10.008. **Read at source via the European PubMed record only: the publisher's own page returned 403, so the authors' limitations section was not available to this desk, and the caveats printed above are its own rather than theirs. No second outlet has covered the paper.** 2 Modarelli RE, Molsberry SA, Malave-Ortiz S, Calvert M, Lucien J, Denslow S, Zaccaro D, Kamoun C and Shaw ND, "Natural History of Menstrual Pain and Associated Risk Factors in Early Adolescence", *Journal of Pediatric and Adolescent Gynecology* 38(1):52–59, online 5 November 2024, doi 10.1016/j.jpag.2024.10.006, **read at source**, for the cohort, the sampling, both ratios and the null findings on activity, anxiety and depression. 3 Media Selangor, 9 November 2026, read at source. 4 Sung C-M, Lin C-H and colleagues, "School-level peer digital distraction, mathematics performance, creative thinking, and adolescent well-being", *Journal of Global Health* 16:04351, 6 November 2026, doi 10.7189/jogh.16.04351, read at source; the design is cross-sectional.

THE MACRO DESK · THE BREAKEVEN STOPS WORKING

Falling Brent stopped easing financial conditions once real yields rose

The ten-year inflation breakeven in America fell another eight basis points from 3 November to 2.22 per cent, while the ten-year real yield rose four to 2.66. October inflation prints after this edition closes — with no annual rate at all.

The cheapest oil in five months stopped making money cheaper this week. Brent fell four to six per cent on Monday to the low nineties, from above $112 at the start of November; the market's expectation of American inflation over the next decade fell eight basis points with it, to 2.22 per cent. The cost of borrowing after inflation went the other way, up four to 2.66.[1]

That divergence is the regime in one line. The inflation premium is still draining away, but the real cost of capital is rising underneath it, so nominal yields barely move and nothing gets easier.[1]

The selling was mechanical: on 5 November, within ninety minutes of the open, trend-followers and leveraged funds cut more than $70bn of equity exposure on JPMorgan's estimate. Then Friday's payrolls came in at 165,000 against a consensus near 65,000, and the rate path turned back up.[2]

THE LEVELS · MONDAY 9 NOVEMBER

INSTRUMENT	LEVEL	CHANGE
VWRA	$187.54	▲ 1.38% d/d
AGGU	$5.84	▼ 0.14% d/d
US 10-year	4.88%	▲ 2bp
10-year real	2.66%	▲ 3bp
Breakeven	2.22%	▼ 8bp wk
Dollar index	101.67	▼ 0.61%
USD/SGD	1.2789	▼ 0.30%
Gold	$4,138.70	▲ 1.69%
Bitcoin	$74,882	▼ 2.7% wk

Delayed quotes for the funds; a dealer bid for gold; one untimestamped source for bitcoin. Not advice.[3]

THE VERDICT · WHAT IT MEANS FOR VWRA, GLOBAL BONDS, GOLD AND BITCOIN

World equities carry the adjustment, because 2.66 per cent is the highest real cost of capital this cycle has taken into a drawdown: down 2.97 per cent from the 4 November high, still 1.14 on the week. **Global bonds** hedged, barely — insurance, not a position, and the week's one reassuring number. **Gold** prices the dollar and the haven, not the real yield: up 1.69 per cent as the dollar fell 0.61, yet still lower on the month, because a 2.66 real yield is punishing carry on an asset that pays nothing. **Bitcoin** prices liquidity alone and fails the haven test outright. **Explanation, not advice.**[3]

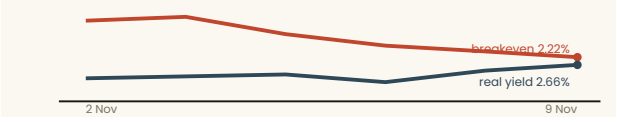
THE SCEPTIC · "THE AI BUBBLE DIDN'T POP. HEDGE FUND LEVERAGE DID."

Jordi Visser of 22V Research says the regime above is mis-specified, and is putting money behind it. His diagnosis of 5 November: gross exposure, not conviction, was the binding constraint — "They cannot get the gross down enough." Against December rate-rise odds in the seventies he argues real yields have turned down and expects at least one large negative inflation print. He is honest about the risk: this is "just the beginning of the hedge fund deleveraging".[4]

HIGHER-FOR-LONGER · DOLLAR SOFTER · LEVERAGE UNWIND

$70bn

OF EQUITY EXPOSURE CUT BY TREND-FOLLOWERS AND LEVERAGED FUNDS WITHIN NINETY MINUTES OF THE OPEN ON 5 NOVEMBER[2]



The two legs of the ten-year yield, 2 to 9 November. Shapes indicative; end points are the Treasury's own. *Meridian* original.[1]

SOURCES 1 The United States Treasury's own daily par yield and real yield curve files for November 2026, **read at source**, for every yield quoted; the breakeven is this desk's subtraction of the real curve from the nominal one, a proxy for and not a reading of the published series. Brent is given as a range because sources disagree: Trading Economics had $92.72 and intraday wire copy $94.11 and $93.73 at different hours on the same contract day. 2 StoneX's market commentary of 6 November, read at source, for the JPMorgan and Morgan Stanley leverage estimates and the midterm trigger; the payroll print and unemployment rate are the 6 November release. 3 Levels at Monday 9 November, each read at source instrument by instrument; **gold is a dealer bid at 16:10 New York time rather than the London benchmark, which has moved behind a licence wall, and bitcoin has a single untimestamped source whose own summary and table disagree on the size of the daily move.** American equity closes for 9 November were not obtainable and are deliberately absent. The Federal Reserve chair is Kevin Warsh and the funds target is 3.75–4.00 per cent after a September increase. **American October inflation is released on 10 November at 8.30am New York time, after this edition closes — and will carry no year-over-year rate, because the October 2025 index was never collected during the shutdown. Any annual figure circulating is a reconstruction, and none is printed here.** 4 Jordi Visser of 22V Research, 8 November 2026, as reported and quoted at source; his position disclosures are his own.

THE INVITATION · HEMA & THE LONGSWORD

HEMA rebuilds European swordfighting out of the books its masters wrote

Wiktenauer's free library holds 23,459 uploaded files; the global ladder lists 21,423 fencers and 418,696 recorded fights. Germany's federation counts 4,135 people, against more than 23,000 Olympic fencers.

HEMA — historical European martial arts — is the reconstruction of how Europeans actually fought, taken from the instruction books their own masters wrote between roughly 1300 and 1900, and this page is about what those books are and how many people are now obeying them. The books are called treatises, and until about 2009 most of them sat unread in European libraries.[1]

It is not the fencing you see at the Olympics, which descends from one narrow duelling tradition and was standardised into three weapons with scoring conventions and an electric wire. It is not the medieval re-enactment societies either, whose combat is a modern ruleset of their own devising. The distinction that matters is where the authority sits: a sport fencer obeys a rulebook, and a HEMA fencer is trying to obey a dead man.[1]

The dead man, mostly, is Johannes Liechtenauer, whose late-fourteenth-century verse was deliberately written to be obscure and was then explained by generations of glossators. His tradition runs through "many dozens of manuscripts and books" over nearly three centuries. The Italian line runs from Fiore dei Liberi around 1400 through the Bolognese sidesword masters to the rapier. Longsword dominates the modern practice: the German and Austrian census found it taught at over 88 per cent of training locations in both countries.[2]

The on-ramp is now the library plus a trial night. Wiktenauer, the volunteer wiki that put the sources online free, holds 55,808 pages and 23,459 uploaded files and describes a corpus of "well over a thousand" books and manuscripts. You can read Liechtenauer tonight for nothing and be hit with a blunt sword on Thursday for about twenty Singapore dollars.[3]

THE CHATTER · HOW BIG THE HEMA WORLD ACTUALLY IS

The rating site is the only global census, and it counts fights rather than people who say they fence. HEMA Ratings lists **6,274 tournaments, 21,423 fighters and 418,696 individual bouts** across nine weapons. Steel longsword alone, in its open and men's set, accounts for 14,998 fighters and 185,568 fights; sabre is the clear second at 5,910. Germany's federation, the best-governed national body in the sport, reported **97 member groups across 121 locations and 4,135 fencers** in August 2025, growing about nine per cent in 2024 and nineteen in 2025 — and volunteered the comparison itself: German **Olympic** fencing has over 23,000 members.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · THE NUMBER THIS DESK REFUSED TO PRINT

You will read that there are 160,000 practitioners in the United States. There is no survey behind it. The figure traces to a 2020 article extrapolating from Facebook advertising-audience data; the same page's own club finder listed **215 American schools**. A January 2020 count it disputes put the worldwide figure at 16,336. This desk prints the 215 and the rating-site totals and nothing else, because those are counts of things rather than estimates of interest — and because the honest shape of this hobby is small, not large. Germany has 4,135 federated fencers in a country of 84 million, and its own federation expects growth to slow in 2026 unless new members stay.[5]

7

WIKTENAUER EDITORS ACTIVE IN THE LAST THIRTY DAYS, AGAINST 662 REGISTERED USERS, MAINTAINING THE WHOLE LIBRARY[3]

SOURCES 1 Wiktenauer's own About page, last edited 13 January 2026, **read at source**, for the definition of the corpus, its date range and the "well over a thousand" description; the comparisons with sport fencing and the re-enactment societies are this desk's own framing. 2 Wiktenauer's Liechtenauer page, read at source, for the tradition's span; Fürgut, "The state of HEMA in 2021: The German & Austrian HEMA census", *Acta Periodica Duellatorum*, **read at source**, for the 88 per cent figure and the discipline ranking. 3 Wiktenauer's own statistics page, **read at source on 9 November 2026**, for 55,808 pages and 23,459 files. **The same page reports 209 "content pages", which is an artefact of how the wiki is configured and is deliberately not printed as a count of treatises.** The Singapore trial price is on p17. 4 HEMA Ratings' own front-page table, **read at source on 9 November 2026**, for every tournament, fighter and fight figure; the German federation's official release via Sword STEM, dated 5 September 2025, **read at source**, for the group, location and member counts, the growth rates and the Olympic comparison, which is the federation's own. 5 historicaleuropeanmartialarts.com, article of 30 June 2020, **read at source**, which states its own method as an extrapolation from advertising-audience data and carries both the 215-school club-finder count and the 16,336 figure it disputes.

THE DEEP END · THE FEDER AND THE FLEX

The Iron Gate Exhibition caps longsword flex and bans a glove

Nearly every serious training sword is the same spring steel at the same hardness, so the money buys flex, balance and a hand-guard. One American event's rules say simply: "No Red Dragons."

A **HEMA longsword costs between about three hundred and twelve hundred euros, and almost none of that difference is the steel.** The training sword is called a feder, after the stylised spring shape above its handle, and the serious makers all use the same alloy, heat-treated into the same narrow hardness window. What you actually pay for is how the thing bends and where its weight sits.[1]

Flex is the number that governs everything, because it is what tournaments measure. A sword is bent against a scale and the force is read off in kilos or pounds; too stiff and it can injure, too whippy and it cannot be controlled. This is the single most useful thing a newcomer can know: you buy flex to the ruleset of the events you intend to enter, not to taste, and a blade can be rejected for being too flexible as easily as too rigid.[1]

The specifics: Regenyei and Sigi Forge both publish 51CrV4 spring steel at 49–51 HRC. Regenyei grades its standard feder light at 7–9.5kg, medium at 11.5–13 and strong at 13.5–15, with a blade 5mm thick at the base, a point of balance 6–7cm from the crossguard, and a mass between 1,330 and 1,460 grams. The Iron Gate Exhibition's 2026 ruleset caps longsword flex at 40 pounds hard and recommends 35; sword-and-buckler at 35 and 30; sabre at 25 and 20, with a 750-gram weight limit.[2]

The prices, read off the makers' own pages this week: Regenyei's standard and custom feders both start at €280 excluding tax, with six to eight weeks' production; Sigi's range runs 290 to 430 euros; Castille's American-made longswords 360 to 575 dollars; Krieger's 414 to 670. At the top, Arms & Armor's Fechtschule feder is $1,250, copied from a pair of originals by Ulrich Diefstetter of Munich in the Metropolitan Museum, in a limited run of ten.[3]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE RULESETS ARGUE ABOUT

The sport's loudest argument is now conducted with instruments. On **3 November 2026**, Sean Franklin of Sword STEM published measurements of **381 feders taken at one American tournament and 254 at an English league**, against a set of genuinely sharp swords, and concluded the sharps "were not qualitatively different from competition feders in flex" — the training tools are not the soft toys the objection assumes. He flags his own selection bias. The older argument, over whether leagues are turning a martial art into a sport, has had no serious essay since 2016.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · THE CHEAP LADDER DOES NOT REACH THE FLOOR

The most quoted sentence in HEMA equipment this year is three words long, and it is in a ruleset. The Iron Gate Exhibition's 2026 requirements for longsword read: purpose-built gloves with hard hand protection, "Light gloves and lacrosse gloves are not sufficient. **No Red Dragons.**" Red Dragons are the cheapest and most common gloves in the hobby. Single-layer jackets are likewise unacceptable for longsword. For a buy-once reader this is the clearest possible instruction: the budget tier does not lead anywhere, because the events have named it and excluded it.[2]

US$1,500

ROUGHLY WHAT A TOURNAMENT-LEGAL KIT COSTS BEFORE SHIPPING AND TAX — FEDER, 1600-NEWTON MASK, OCCIPITAL OVERLAY, GORGET, 800-NEWTON JACKET, PLASTRON, LIMB ARMOUR AND PURPOSE-BUILT GLOVES[5]

SOURCES 1 Regenyei Armory's and Sigi Forge's own product pages, **both read at source on 9 November 2026**, for the alloy, the hardness window and the flex grades; the account of what flex does is this desk's own, drawn from the rulesets at note 2. 2 The Iron Gate Exhibition's Spring 2026 ruleset, **read at source as the event's own PDF and quoted verbatim**, for every flex limit, the sabre weight cap, the glove requirement including the named exclusion, the jacket requirements and the inspection schedule. 3 Regenyei Armory, Sigi Forge, Castille Armory, Krieger Armory (via Kult of Athena) and Arms & Armor, **all read at source on 9 November 2026**, for every price and lead time quoted; prices are as printed, with Regenyei's and Sigi's exclusive of value-added tax. **Ensifer, Kvetun and Danelli Armouries did not resolve or returned errors, so no prices for them appear.** 4 Sean Franklin, "Are Feders *Actually* Less Stiff Than Sharps?", Sword STEM, 3 November 2026, **read at source**, for the sample sizes, the conclusion and his own caveat; the sportification argument is dated from Leon Paul's 2016 essay and the 2014 reply at HEMA Misfits, both read at source. **Reddit was unreachable for this entire build, so no r/wma sentiment appears anywhere in this desk.** 5 This desk's own arithmetic, summing component prices each read at source from Regenyei, Absolute Force and Purpleheart Armoury, and the Polish maker SPES; it excludes shipping, duty and tax, which for Singapore are on p17.

THE DEEP END · SINGAPORE & THE RUNNING COSTS

Bastion charges S$21.50 for a first HEMA lesson, then S$202.50 monthly

Singapore has two historical fencing organisations, founded in 2005 and 2017. The sword is the easy part: shipping a feder from Hungary costs €150 before nine per cent tax, and the blade rusts here.

Singapore has exactly two places to learn HEMA, and between them they define the whole cost of entry here. Bastion Historical Fencing Academy, in the Tailee Building on Jalan Pemimpin, three minutes from Marymount station, was founded in 2017 by Lucien Lee and Langley Qu, a married couple who picked the sport up in Britain.[1]

Try before you buy anything, because the clubs lend equipment and the equipment is most of the money. A first adult session at Bastion is **S$21.50** for ninety minutes with all gear provided; membership then runs from **S$202.50** a month to S$349.70, with about a fifth off for a three-month commitment. A teens programme for thirteen to seventeens is S$179.20. The adult path starts not with the longsword but with the *langes messer*, for footwork and fundamental cuts.[1]

Swords are controlled items here, and the import route runs through the police licensing department rather than the postman. Then the arithmetic: Regenyei's published rate to ship a feder to Asia is **€150**, against €40 within Europe, and Singapore's nine per cent tax falls on the delivered value, shipping included. A €280 sword lands nearer €470.[2]

THE CHATTER · KEEPING STEEL ALIVE AT BASTION'S LATITUDE

Bastion lends gear, but the sword a member eventually buys has to survive this climate, and the maker that says most about that is Arms & Armor, whose care page is blunt: any steel weapon "should be stored in a dry area after a thorough oiling", with a wipe-on oil because "many spray-on oils will evaporate quickly"; and blades "should not be stored in their leather sheaths", because "leather holds moisture longer than the air around us". In Singapore that is a weekly ritual, not an annual one.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · THE INSTITUTIONS ARE THINNER THAN THE SPORT

HEMA's growth rests on volunteers who are visibly running out, and the evidence is in the obituaries. Longpoint, North America's flagship from 2010 to 2019, posted a hiatus notice that still stands: "There currently exist no future plans for Longpoint… Because we don't have the answers." Swordfish, Europe's flagship, has no event in the global rating list for the thirteen months to 31 October, and its Swedish domain now redirects to a for-sale page.[4]

NEXT DESCENTS · VOTE FOR TOMORROW'S HOBBY

Netsuke & miniature carving — boxwood, antler and a legal minefield, carved at thumbnail scale.

Change ringing (English tower bells) — a permutation algorithm you perform with a rope and a ton of bronze.

Technical diving (caves & wrecks) — rebreathers, gas maths and a community that writes its own fatality reports.

€150

REGENYEI'S OWN PUBLISHED COST TO SHIP ONE SWORD TO ASIA, AGAINST €40 INSIDE EUROPE — BEFORE NINE PER CENT TAX ON THE LOT[2]

SOURCES 1 Bastion Historical Fencing Academy's own site, including its fees and find-us pages, **read at source on 9 November 2026**, for the address, the founding year and founders, the first-session and membership prices and the teens programme; all prices are as printed and the academy states they are subject to change. PHEMAS's own site, read at source, for its 2005 founding, its registration and its venue; **it publishes no fees, timetable or weapon list.** 2 Regenyei Armory's own shipping page, **read at source**, for the €150 Asia rate against €40 within Europe and for its statement that buyers outside the European Union pay no value-added tax but do pay local import charges; Singapore's rate and its application to the delivered value are confirmed on the Inland Revenue Authority's and Singapore Customs' own pages, both read at source. **The precise import-licensing route for swords could not be read at source — the police force's own controlled-items document returned 404 — so it is described in general terms only, and readers should check with the licensing department rather than rely on this page.** 3 Arms & Armor's own care page, **read at source and quoted verbatim**. 4 Longpoint's own news site, post of 31 March 2019, read at source and quoted verbatim; HEMA Ratings' event archive and the Gothenburg school's own site, both read at source, for the absence of a Swordfish edition; hroarr.com, read at source, for its last dated article; Wiktenauer's statistics page for the user counts; the German federation's own autumn 2026 news post of 6 November, read at source, for the vice-president's departure and the workload description.

FITNESS · THE TWO-MINUTE REST

Brad Schoenfeld's team found fixed two-minute rests matched self-chosen ones

Forty trained lifters, eight weeks, lower body only: in Schoenfeld's trial the differences in muscle growth and strength were trivial, but the fixed group finished each session in 56 minutes against 78.5.

A randomised trial published on 6 November by Brad Schoenfeld's group found that lifters told to rest a fixed two minutes between sets gained as much as lifters left to rest however long they felt like — and finished training about twenty-nine per cent sooner. Forty resistance-trained men and women trained for eight weeks, four sets of eight to twelve repetitions, squat and calf work.[1]

The appeal for anyone training around a job is obvious, and so is the catch. Left to themselves the self-selecting group drifted: 3.7 minutes between sets against the prescribed 2.4, and a session-length gap that widened from nineteen minutes in week one to thirty-two by week eight. Nothing about their training got better for it.[2]

The differences were, in the authors' Bayesian terms, trivial: muscle growth favoured the fixed group by a tenth of a standard deviation, and performance was flat at zero. Effort felt identical — 8.2 against 8.1 on a ten-point scale. Session length was 56.0 minutes against 78.5.[1]

One caveat matters most for a reader in his forties: **neither the journal abstract nor the preprint states the participants' ages**, and the only write-up that does puts them at eighteen to forty. This is a time-efficiency principle that plausibly transfers; it is not evidence in mid-forties lifters. **General guidance, not medical advice.**[2]

THE CHATTER · THE EVIDENCE SCHOENFELD'S TRIAL LANDS IN

The best check on Schoenfeld's eight-week trial of forty people is the meta-analysis of everything acute that came before it. **Lv and colleagues** pooled **16 studies and 281 participants** in *PLOS ONE* in July and found the difference between self-selected and prescribed rest indistinguishable from zero on performance — 0.27, with a confidence interval of −0.14 to 0.69 — and exactly zero on heart rate. Their own limitations are frank: few studies, mostly crossover designs, acute responses only, and 46 women among the 281.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · A STOPWATCH EFFECT, NOT A PHYSIOLOGICAL ONE

Read the meta-analysis against the new trial and the honest verdict on prescribed rest is that it saves you half an hour, not that it does anything to your muscles. The pooled prediction interval on performance ran from −1.30 to 1.85 — another way of saying the next study could land anywhere. What the Schoenfeld trial convincingly measures is a clock. One design detail matters before you copy it: phones and conversation were banned, so the self-selected rests reflect recovery rather than distraction — which means in a real gym the penalty is probably *larger*, and still has nothing to do with physiology.[3]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Moderate intervals moved mitochondria as much as hard ones. Eleven untrained men, seven weeks, four forty-minute cycling sessions a week: muscle oxygen capacity rose about 50 per cent and power at lactate threshold by about 43 watts, published 3 November. **Eleven young men is a mechanism, not a prescription**, and no confidence intervals were reported — but it is a shot at the orthodoxy that only the painful intervals count.[4]

SOURCES 1 Mohan AE, Piñero A, Coleman M, Hopper A, Segtnan R, Montenegro D, Hermann T, Androulakis Korakakis P, Wolf M, Swinton PA and Schoenfeld BJ, "Freedom of Choice? Effects of Self-Selected Rest Intervals on Muscular Adaptations", *International Journal of Sports Medicine*, published online 6 November 2026, doi 10.1055/a-2999-0052. **Read at source via the European PubMed record and the authors' own open preprint; the publisher's typeset text was behind an anti-robot interstitial, and neither the abstract nor the preprint page carries a limitations section.** 2 *Evidence Based Muscle*, Robbie Durand, 25 July 2026, **read at source**, for the participants' age range, the mean rest times, the widening session gap and the banned phones; it is the only account this desk found that states the ages at all. 3 Lv L, Chen C, Liu X, Liu H and Wu P, "Systematic review and meta-analysis of the acute effects of self-selected rest intervals…", *PLOS ONE* 21(7):e0354594, 24 July 2026, doi 10.1371/journal.pone.0354594, **full text read at source including its limitations section, from which the four caveats are quoted in substance**. 4 Zoladz JA and colleagues, "Moderate-Intensity Interval Training Is Sufficient to Increase Muscle Mitochondrial Respiratory Capacity…", *Medicine & Science in Sports & Exercise*, ahead of print 3 November 2026, doi 10.1249/MSS.0000000000004203, read at source via the European PubMed record; **the full text is subscription-only, so no authors' limitations were available and none are claimed.** 5 Li D, Göger L, Krüger N, Aleithe M and Herpich C, *Age & Ageing* 55(11):afag323, 31 October 2026, doi 10.1093/ageing/afag323, read at source; the moderator analyses are the authors' own and are described by them as exploratory.

THE DIARY · CHRISTMAS WONDERLAND

Gardens by the Bay dated Christmas Wonderland and published no prices

The dates went up this week: 27 November to 3 January, 6.30pm to 11pm at Supertree Grove. The ticket line on the same page reads, for the fifth issue running, "Ticket prices will be released soon."

SINGAPORE

BOOK NOW · PLAN AHEAD

27 Nov–3 Jan ★ **Christmas Wonderland 2026**
SUPERTREE GROVE & THE MEADOW · **6.30PM–11PM, LAST ADMISSION 10.15PM** · THE DATES ARE NOW ON GARDENS BY THE BAY'S OWN PAGE; THE PRICE LINE STILL SAYS "TICKET PRICES WILL BE RELEASED SOON" · SEVENTEEN DAYS TO THE GATE[1]

25 NOV ★ **Guns N' Roses · World Tour 2026**
NATIONAL STADIUM · DOORS 5PM, SHOW 7PM · ON GENERAL SALE SINCE 20 MARCH, SO LATE-STAGE SEATS ONLY · **THE VENUE PUBLISHES NO PRICE GRID**, ONLY BOOKING FEES OF $6 TO $10 A TICKET BY BAND[2]

28–29 Nov ★ **BABYMONSTER · two nights**
SINGAPORE INDOOR STADIUM · DOORS 4.30PM, SHOW 6PM · **S$168 TO S$358** BEFORE FEES · **THE SECOND NIGHT IS NEW SINCE NO. 157**, THOUGH THE VENUE'S OWN BODY COPY STILL DESCRIBES ONLY THE 28TH[3]

14–15 Nov **SSO · Family Film Favourites**
VICTORIA CONCERT HALL · **11AM AND 2PM BOTH DAYS** · THE ONLY MATINEE-TIMED, EXPLICITLY FAMILY-PROGRAMMED CONCERT IN THE WINDOW · NO PRICES ON THE ORCHESTRA'S LISTING[4]

20–29 Nov **Kalaa Utsavam · Indian Festival of Arts**
ESPLANADE · MIXED FREE AND TICKETED, THE HOUSE'S USUAL MODEL, WITH NO PRICES AT LISTING LEVEL · MUARA FESTIVAL RUNS 13–15 NOV ON THE SAME PAGE[5]

18 Nov–6 Dec ***Eureka Day* · Singapore Repertory Theatre**
KC ARTS CENTRE · PRICES NOT PUBLISHED AND THE BOX OFFICE SHOWED AS CLOSED WHEN READ · **ADULT THEATRE — NOT THE FAMILY ROW**[6]

4–6 Dec **BYD Singapore International Marathon**
F1 PIT BUILDING TO THE NATIONAL STADIUM · **REGISTRATION CLOSED 30 SEPTEMBER**; MARATHON, HALF AND CREW CHALLENGE ALL SHOW SOLD OUT AT LOCAL PRICING · A SPECTATOR AND ROAD-CLOSURE ITEM NOW[7]

22–24 Jan **ART SG 2027 · early bird ends 24 Nov**
MARINA BAY SANDS · TWO-FOR-ONE ADULT PASSES **S$40–S$44** AGAINST S$80–S$88, OFFER ENDS **24 NOVEMBER 11.59PM** · **UNDER-16S FREE WITH A PAYING ADULT** — THE BEST FAMILY ECONOMICS ON THIS PAGE[8]

JAPAN & THE REGION

WORTH THE FLIGHT

10–24 Jan ★ **Hatsu Basho · tickets 5 Dec**
RYOGOKU KOKUGIKAN, TOKYO · **ADVANCE SALES OPEN 5 DECEMBER 2026** · CONFIRMED ON THE SUMO ASSOCIATION'S OWN JAPANESE PAGES; **ITS ENGLISH PATHS ALL SERVE AN ERROR PAGE**, SO BOOK THROUGH THE JAPANESE PORTAL[9]

13 Nov–14 Feb ***Le Petit Prince* · opens Friday**
TOKYO CITY VIEW, ROPPONGI HILLS · THE 80TH ANNIVERSARY OF THE FRENCH PUBLICATION · SAME COMPLEX AS THE TWO BELOW — ONE TICKET RUN, THREE SHOWS, ONE AFTERNOON[10]

30 Oct–11 Jan **HAIKYU!! Challengers**
MORI ARTS CENTER GALLERY, ROPPONGI HILLS · HARUICHI FURUDATE'S VOLLEYBALL MANGA · **THE TWELVE-YEAR-OLD'S EVENT OF THE SEASON** · PRICES NOT PUBLISHED ON THE MUSEUM'S LISTING[10]

31 Oct–28 Mar **Mariko Mori · *All That Shines***
MORI ART MUSEUM, ROPPONGI HILLS · RUNS TO 28 MARCH 2027, SO NO RUSH · LISTING LINKS TO TICKETS BUT PUBLISHES NO PRICE[10]

28 Oct–8 Feb ***Shojo Manga Infinity***
THE NATIONAL ART CENTER, TOKYO · MOTO HAGIO, RYOKO YAMAGISHI AND WAKI YAMATO · THE LOUVRE RENAISSANCE SHOW IN THE SAME BUILDING CLOSES **13 DECEMBER**[11]

10–31 Jan **Australian Open 2027**
MELBOURNE · **THAT SPAN INCLUDES QUALIFYING AND OPENING WEEK**, NOT A THREE-WEEK MAIN DRAW · THE TOURNAMENT'S OWN PAGE CARRIES NO ON-SALE DATE AND DOES NOT NAME THE VENUE[12]

25–27 Mar **Art Basel Hong Kong 2027**
HONG KONG · DATES CONFIRMED ON THE FAIR'S OWN PAGE, WHICH GIVES **NO VENUE AND NO TICKET INFORMATION** — THE CONVENTION CENTRE IS THE HISTORIC HOME BUT THE PAGE DOES NOT SAY SO[13]

SOURCES Every event on this page was re-verified on its promoter's, venue's or official ticketing page on 9–10 November 2026, and the wording quoted is theirs. 1 Gardens by the Bay's own Christmas Wonderland 2026 page, **read at source**, for the dates, hours, last admission, venue and the price sentence quoted verbatim; **the Gardens' general calendar page still renders as unfilled template placeholders and lists no events at all, and christmaswonderland.sg carries no dates.** 2 The Kallang's own event page. 3 The Kallang's own event page, which carries the full price ladder and both dates in its header while describing only 28 November in its body — an inconsistency flagged here rather than resolved. 4 The Singapore Symphony Orchestra's own listing. 5 Esplanade's own festivals listing. 6 Singapore Repertory Theatre's own site. 7 The Kallang's own event page, including the closing date and the sold-out markers. 8 ART SG's own site and its tickets page, for the dates, every price and the children's pass wording. 9 The Japan Sumo Association's own Japanese-language pages, **read at source** — its English tournament and ticket paths all return the association's own error page, and the English ticket portal returned 503. 10 The Mori Art Museum's own exhibitions listing. 11 The National Art Center's own English listing. 12 The Australian Open's own homepage. 13 Art Basel's own Hong Kong page. **Sapporo's snow festival is omitted this issue: its official site was still serving the 2025 edition when read, so no 2027 date could be verified.**

THE TABLE · THREE OPENINGS, HONESTLY COUNTED

Two friends who met playing League of Legends opened Cranki Patisserie

Cranki Patisserie, Casa Osteria and AhMah's Legacy are the three Singapore openings this desk could stand up — out of roughly sixty written up since mid-October. The rest had all run here before.

Cranki Patisserie is the first shop for a home bakery, opened in King Albert Park mall by Laura Lee and Brenan Yeo, two friends who met playing League of Legends and are credited with no formal pastry training anywhere this desk could read. The signatures are Southeast-Asian choux au craquelin at S$8 — masala chai, honeycomb chrysanthemum — and a S$72 dacquoise ordered two days ahead.[1]

The buzz is one sentence long, and this desk could not read it at source. A Burpple user wrote: "I think I just found my new favourite choux puffs at Cranki Patisserie!" — reached only through a search snippet, because Burpple refused every request. One customer, not a consensus; nobody has reviewed the place. Go before noon; budget S$15–25 for two pastries and a coffee.[1]

Casa Osteria is a build-your-own pasta stall inside Chomp Chomp, Serangoon's supper hawker centre — restaurant Italian at food-centre money, pasta from S$6.90. No chef and no group are credited. One publication has eaten there, liked the Genova pesto at S$13.90 and praised the S$12.90 chilli crab pasta for containing real crab meat. Mild approval from a single outlet; nothing else exists. S$7–17 a head, no bookings.[1]

AhMah's Legacy is the one with a story, and the one that needs a caveat: it is a **relocation**, not a debut. Shiny Phua has moved her kueh business out of a dim Thomson basement into 22 Sin Ming Road, and shapes the ang ku kueh with her grandmother's thirty-year-old wooden mould. The verdict, from the one outlet that has been: "Yes, AhMah's Legacy is definitely worth a visit!" Pork-free by the shop's own account, but **not halal-certified.**[2]

THE VERDICT · WHY THIS PAGE CARRIES THREE VENUES AND NOT SIX

This desk went looking for six openings and found three, and the reason is worth printing. The Table ledger bars 131 venue names that have had their two runs here. Against that bar, the complete November coverage — five publications' lists, forty-nine venues — produced almost nothing new. Three more were not new at all. One was dropped because its own abbreviation collides with a barred name. **The window from mid-October is now fully enumerable, and it has been eaten.**[3]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT "NEW OPENING" IS ACTUALLY MEASURING

Half of what Singapore's food press calls a new opening is a brand's second, third or seventh address. On one November list of eighteen, one entry was a menu update and one a third outlet; on another of twelve, one was a seventh outlet. None of that is dishonest, but a reader counting openings is counting leases, not kitchens. Which is the fair charge against this page too: **AhMah's Legacy** is a move, labelled as one rather than quietly counted as a debut.[3]

PLANNING NOTES

Almost every big thing on p19 **is already past its on-sale** — Guns N' Roses in March, BABYMONSTER in June, the marathon in September. The one live window with a hard deadline is **ART SG's early bird, 24 November**. And treat any sub-face resale listing as suspect: aggregators were quoting BABYMONSTER seats at roughly S$131–165 against an official S$168 floor.[3]

CHOUX S$8 · PASTA FROM S$6.90 · KUEH S$6 · NONE HALAL-CERTIFIED

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VENUES BARRED BY THE TABLE LEDGER[3]

SOURCES 1 HungryGoWhere's new-openings round-up of 3 November 2026 by Shannon Yap, **read at source**, for both venues' concepts, founders, menus and every price quoted, and for the only published assessment of either; the Burpple line is **a search-result snippet and is flagged as such because burpple.com returned 403 to every request. Cranki's own site could not be resolved from this desk, and Instagram returned 429 on every handle attempted across two sessions, so no venue-published hours are printed.** 2 middleclass.sg, 2 November 2026, Ming Yu Lim, **read at source**, for the address, the founder, the mould, every price and the verdict quoted; the halal position is the shop's own, as recorded there, and is printed as uncertified. 3 This desk's own enumeration, 9–10 November 2026, against `ledgers/table-ledger.md`: the dated opening feeds of Eatbook and HungryGoWhere and the November lists of TheSmartLocal, Honeycombers, SassyMama and The Ranting Panda were each read and checked name by name. **The Michelin Guide's Singapore pages rendered empty; Time Out Singapore, SETHLUI, Burpple and The Urban List all refused this desk; City Nomads has published no November edition. Four previously-run venues were demoted rather than given a second run they had not earned, because none of them has yet been reviewed by anybody — a verdict run with no verdict in it is what this ledger exists to prevent.**

THE UNDERCURRENT · JAPAN'S NISA POOR

Japan's NISA poor starve themselves to fill Tokyo's tax allowance

「NISA貧乏」 reached the floor of the Diet in March and the shortlist for Japan's 2026 word of the year on 5 November. Accounts passed 30,480,850 in June, and purchases ¥85 trillion against a government target of ¥56tn.

On 19 June this year, nine people in their thirties, forties and fifties met in an event bar in Naka-ku, Nagoya, to talk about how little they had been eating. The man who organised it is 33, a company employee. He had spent the previous eighteen months on banana for breakfast, oatmeal for lunch and soba at night, wearing the same clothes daily and practising, as he put it, every economy going. He had filled the whole of his annual tax-free investment allowance, and compared the feeling to finishing exam season. The low point, he said, was seeing a friend's holiday photographs.[1]

The word for what he was doing is 「NISA貧乏」 — NISA binbō, NISA poverty. It describes a person who has cut food, friends and self-improvement to the bone in order to push the maximum into the state's tax-free investment account, and it is now sufficiently established in Japanese life to have been argued about in parliament, written up in the business press, turned into a meetup brand, and, on 5 November, shortlisted for the country's word of the year. The winner is announced on 1 December.[1]

The scheme itself is unremarkable and rather good. The Nippon Individual Savings Account, remodelled on 1 January 2024, made the tax exemption permanent and raised the ceilings to ¥3.6m a year and ¥18m in a lifetime. It has worked far better than intended: **30,480,850 accounts** at the end of June, up 8.06 per cent in six months, with cumulative purchases of **¥85 trillion** against a government target of ¥56tn by the end of 2027. One in four Japanese adults now holds one, the finance minister told the Diet.[2]

That is the whole of it. A ceiling was announced, and a certain kind of person read it as an instruction. The minister who administers the policy has said so herself: accumulation becoming the goal "was never intended at all".[3]

THE MOMENT · 10 MARCH 2026, LOWER HOUSE FINANCE COMMITTEE

The phrase entered the official record when **Tanaka Ken**, of the Democratic Party for the People, asked the finance minister whether she had heard it. "Driven by anxiety, people are increasingly saying 'NISA for now, index funds for now'," he said. "The accumulation itself becomes the purpose." His point was about age: a person in their twenties needs to invest, "but much more, investing in oneself… it is an important time to do many things". **Katayama Satsuki**, the finance minister, replied that she had read the magazine article behind the question and "was rather shocked". Three weeks later she noted drily that her being shocked had itself become an internet news story.[3]

THE FRACTURE · "A PRECONDITION, NOT A CHOICE"

On 9 April, in the upper house, **Ehara Kumiko** put the social reading on the record, and it is the sharpest line any politician has produced on this: among young people "there is a division between those doing NISA and those not", and investment "is being received not as a choice but as a precondition". The numbers bear her out in a way that cuts against the panic: **about 80 per cent of Japanese in their twenties have no account at all**, and among those who do, only about 2 per cent of people in their twenties and thirties fill the allowance. Men hold accounts at 22.8 per cent, women at 12.0; regular employees at 26.3 per cent, part-timers at 6.4.[4]

¥85tn

BOUGHT THROUGH THE SCHEME BY JUNE, AGAINST A GOVERNMENT TARGET OF ¥56TN BY THE END OF 2027[2]

SOURCES 1 Tokyo Shimbun, Sato Yusuke, 19 July 2026, **read at source** for the Nagoya gathering, its date, the organiser's age and occupation, his diet, his comparison to exam season and the holiday photographs; **the article is paywalled beyond its opening and only the free portion was read.** The word-of-the-year shortlist of 5 November and the 1 December announcement are the organiser's own published list. 2 Japan's Financial Services Agency survey of 2 October 2026, **parsed at source from the agency's own spreadsheet and graph file**, for the account total, the six-month growth, the ¥85tn cumulative purchases and the government's own ¥56tn target, which the agency prints beside it; the 2024 reform's limits are the scheme's published terms. 3 The National Diet's own record of the House of Representatives finance committee, 10 March 2026, and of the House of Councillors financial affairs committee, 26 March 2026, **read at source through the Diet Library's speech database and translated here**; the minister's "one in four adults" figure is from the same 10 March session. 4 The National Diet record, House of Councillors, 9 April 2026, **read at source**, for Ehara Kumiko's remarks; the 80 per cent figure is Nikkei's estimate from official statistics, 31 July 2026, and the 2 per cent is Nikkei MJ's of 9 November 2026, **both read at source in their free portions only**; the holding rates by sex and employment status are from SMBC Consumer Finance's own survey of 1,000 people in their twenties, published 15 January 2026 and **read at source as the firm's own PDF**.

There is a survey that captures the substitution exactly, and it was published in January, before anyone had a word for it. SMBC Consumer Finance asks a thousand Japanese in their twenties the same questions each year. In the 2026 round, the monthly sum those who invest put into investments rose **¥5,068 to ¥29,678** — up 20.6 per cent in a single year. Over the same twelve months their monthly pocket money fell ¥2,446 to ¥32,159, and their spending on hobbies and leisure fell slightly.[1]

And this, which is the couplet the whole phenomenon turns on: the share spending anything at all on 自己投資 — investment in oneself, meaning skills, study and qualifications — **fell from 29.6 per cent to 24.3**. The share spending on appearance fell from 59.4 to 53.9. A generation increased the money it put into index funds by a fifth, and cut the money it put into itself. The sum they believe they will need by retirement rose ¥2.45m in one year, to ¥22.14m. Nearly seven in ten said they were anxious about their savings.[1]

Five things made this happen at once. The 2024 reform published a cap. The state had already set a target of 34 million accounts and wants households holding 40 per cent of their assets in securities. The 2019 report that put a ¥20m figure on the retirement shortfall gave the anxiety arithmetic. Real disposable income has been falling. And the term itself spread through frugality videos before parliament ever touched it — the Nagoya organiser says he met it in one this spring and thought: that is me.[2]

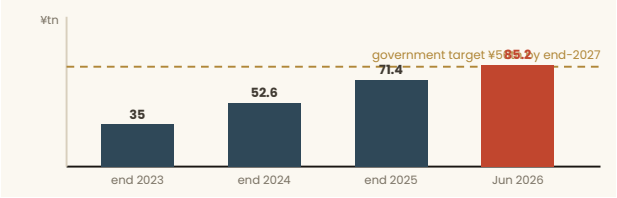
They increased what they put into index funds by a fifth, and cut what they put into themselves.

The dissent is serious and it is Japanese. **Mitadera Kei**, writing in PRESIDENT Online on 29 October, says the premise is wrong: the surveys do not show many twenty-somethings cutting living costs to max the allowance. In 2025, he reports, 48.7 per cent of people in their twenties put ¥200,000 or less a year into the accumulation quota and 74.0 per cent put in ¥400,000 or less — around ¥33,000 a month at the very top of that band. Working households bought a net **¥5,100 a month** of shares while adding **¥177,100** a month to deposits. Blaming young investors for the squeeze, he writes, is missing the forest for the trees; the causes are prices, tax and social insurance.[3]

The economist **Kawada Hiroshi** agrees and then undermines himself usefully. Young households' propensity to consume is flat, he argues, not falling, so the alarm is overdone. But on the household-finance survey he cites, the share of households putting more than a fifth of take-home pay into financial assets is at its highest since the bubble era, the share putting in more than 30 per cent has clearly passed its old peak, and **over 30 per cent of people in their twenties allocate at least 35 per cent of disposable income to financial assets** — against under 10 per cent of the over-sixties.[4]

One number in the agency's own spreadsheet has no explanation attached to it. Accounts held by people in their teens went from 134,413 at the end of December to **490,730** six months later — a rise of 265 per cent in half a year, in an age band where the scheme's minimum age of eighteen leaves only a sliver eligible. This desk could not establish what drove it and will not guess; it is recorded here because it is the strangest line in the file.[5]

Both men are right, and together they describe a vanguard rather than a generation. That is the honest shape of this story: a minority, visible and growing, doing something the majority has not started doing and the state cannot stop recommending.[4]



Cumulative purchases through the scheme, in trillions of yen, from the Financial Services Agency's own transition file. The dashed line is the government's target for the end of 2027, passed by half somewhere in the first half of this year. *Meridian* original, from agency data.[5]

SOURCES 1 SMBC Consumer Finance, "Survey of attitudes to money among people in their twenties, 2026", n=1,000 aged 20–29, fielded 27–28 November 2025 and published 15 January 2026, **read at source as the firm's own PDF**; every figure in these two paragraphs is taken from it, including the self-investment and appearance shares and the retirement estimate. 2 The scheme's published terms for the cap; the account target and the 40-per-cent securities ambition are the government's own stated policy; the ¥20m retirement figure is from the Financial Services Agency's 2019 report; the real-income fall is as cited by Mitadera at note 3 from the household survey; the origin of the phrase is the Nagoya organiser's own account in Tokyo Shimbun (p21). 3 Mitadera Kei, PRESIDENT Online, 29 October 2026, **read at source**, for all four of his figures and for the quoted characterisation. 4 Kawada Hiroshi, JBpress, 14 October 2026, **read at source**; **the household-finance survey percentages are as he reports them and were not read in the underlying release, so they are attributed to him rather than to the surveying body.** 5 Japan's Financial Services Agency, graph file and transition spreadsheet accompanying its survey of 2 October 2026, **parsed at source**; the figure is this desk's own drawing of the agency's published series.

Here is the part nobody in Tokyo seems to have said out loud. The apparatus now urging Japanese households into the stock market is not merely similar to the one that spent seventy years urging them to save. It is the same institution, with the same secretariat lineage, carrying out the opposite instruction.[1]

The chronology is published, by the body itself. A 救国貯蓄運動 — a save-the-nation savings campaign — began in 1946 under the currency stabilisation headquarters. Prefectural savings-promotion committees followed in 1950. In **1952** the Central Council for Savings Promotion was founded, chaired by a former governor of the Bank of Japan, advised by the finance minister, with its secretariat housed **inside the Bank of Japan's head office**. It designated "savings practice districts" in 1958 and appointed "savings promoters" in 1960. It was renamed in 1988, renamed again in 2001 — and in **2024**, the year the new allowance began, it was wound up and its functions transferred to J-FLEC, the new financial-education agency.[1]

Same machine. Opposite verb. Identical grammar: abstain now, be rewarded later.

Seventy-eight years of a state telling its citizens that the virtuous thing to do with money is not spend it. The object changed; the sentence did not. NISA binbō is not a new pathology. It is deflation-era self-denial wearing an index fund, produced by an institution that knows exactly one way to address a household.[1]

Which is why the state's remedy keeps sounding so thin. Asked three times in three sessions what should be done about people over-complying, the minister offered financial education — the output of the agency that inherited the savings council. A nudge has an accelerator and no brake. The government can raise a ceiling; it has no instrument for telling a frightened twenty-six-year-old that ¥3.6m is a maximum and not a target, because every institutional habit it possesses is built to say the opposite.[2]

And the ceiling is being extended downward. The 2026 tax reform abolishes the minimum age on the accumulation quota: from birth, ¥600,000 a year and a ¥6m tax-free cap. The minister declined the obvious name, "children's NISA", preferring the technical formula — the abolition of the age floor. In the same twelve months, Taiwan's president announced a state-managed investment account for every child, NT$2,500 a month from age six, professionally managed, with a guaranteed floor return and the upside belonging to the child at eighteen.[3]

So, in one year, two Asian democracies wired their newborns into equities. And the Nikkei is **19.3 per cent below its June peak** — 58,775.50 against 72,831.73 on 22 June. The first real drawdown of the new era is arriving at the most leveraged-by-abstinence cohort the country has ever produced, and it is arriving as a social event rather than a market one, because the people holding the losses skipped dinners to buy in.[4]

The retail trader **Testa**, the most-followed voice in Japanese markets, has already given them their defence, and it deserves to be printed in full rather than sneered at: "NISA poverty — absolutely fine. I think it's completely fine. It's that person's life. If you spend all your money now and run into trouble later, the people criticising NISA poverty won't take responsibility for you." He is right that the critics will not pay. The question the next decade will put to Japan is whether the state that spent seventy-eight years teaching the sentence will.[5]

1952

THE YEAR THE CENTRAL COUNCIL FOR SAVINGS PROMOTION WAS FOUNDED, WITH ITS SECRETARIAT INSIDE THE BANK OF JAPAN[1]

SOURCES 1 The savings-promotion council's own published chronology, hosted at shiruporuto.jp, **read at source**, for every date, name and transfer in this account: the 1946 campaign, the 1950 prefectural committees, the 1952 founding with its chairman, adviser and the location of its secretariat, the 1958 districts, the 1960 promoters, the 1988 and 2001 renamings, and the 2024 transfer of functions to J-FLEC. **The reading of that lineage as one institution carrying out an opposite instruction is this desk's argument, not the council's.** 2 The National Diet record for 10 March, 26 March and 9 April 2026, **read at source**, for the minister's answers across the three sessions. 3 EY Japan's summary of the 2026 tax reform outline, **read at source**, for the ¥600,000 annual and ¥6m lifetime figures for ages 0–17; the Diet record of 13 March 2026 for the creation of the scheme and for the minister's preference for the technical formulation over the popular name. Taiwan: the Economic Daily News via UDN, 27 May 2026, **read at source**, for President Lai Ching-te's announcement, the NT$2,500 monthly split, the professional management, the floor return and the withdrawal age. **Reporting that the Legislative Yuan passed the enabling statute on 24 July 2026 and that the Executive Yuan objects on constitutional grounds was not readable at source and is therefore not printed as fact.** 4 The index level and its 52-week high, **verified at two sources** on 9 November 2026; the percentage is this desk's arithmetic. 5 Nikkei, 28 October 2026, **read at source**, for Testa's remarks, translated here. **Quotations circulating from a television segment about the Nagoya bar — including a man who said he broke up with his girlfriend to fill the allowance — reached this desk only through aggregators that disagree on which programme broadcast them, and are deliberately not printed.**

THE LAST WORD

The handover

Twice in two hours on 5 November, a trained person in a driverless shuttle at Punggol reached over and took the wheel, exactly as designed. The uncomfortable part is on p5: the last time Singapore investigated one of these, in January, it found the takeover was what caused the crash.

A board took custody of its own founder this week (p7). A volunteer add-on shop one person had carried for years was absorbed by the project it served, to relief and fury in equal measure (p8). An auction house finally published the total this desk had added up for itself — we were 123,318 francs light, which is both a good night's arithmetic and a thing we should not have had to do (p10).

Elsewhere the handover is the whole point. A Yamagata forge in its fourth generation will make you a pruner that cuts better than the Swiss one and sell you nothing to repair it with (p6). A woman in Sin Ming shapes her kueh with her grandmother's thirty-year-old mould (p20). Thousands are trying to obey a fourteenth-century fencing master, from books a handful of volunteers put online — seven of whom edited anything last month (p15).

And the Japanese committee that spent seventy-eight years telling people to save was wound up in 2024, its work given to an agency that tells them to invest (p21). Same desk, opposite verb. A handover is not a transfer of power. It is a transfer of habits, and the habits usually win.

TWELVE DESKS · ONE WORLD

MERIDIAN · No. 158 · 10 November 2026

A note on method. Read at source this edition: Qatar's foreign ministry index (a negative read — no Washington readout exists); the Turkish Official Gazette for 9 and 10 November, in full, neither carrying a law section; Poland's National Prosecutor's Office in Polish; Nvidia's board statement and its founder's memo; the Federal Register stay at 91 FR 70789; Singapore's police, health and environment releases and the Land Transport Authority's January finding; Felco's and Tetsufuku's own price and parts pages; the Home Assistant release post and the SmartThings notice; XREAL's and Ming's own product pages; Phillips' lot pages; the Treasury's yield files; four journal papers in full and six at abstract; the Iron Gate Exhibition's own ruleset; Bastion's fee page; eleven promoters' and venues' own pages; Japan's Financial Services Agency spreadsheets, the Diet's speech record, and the savings council's own chronology. **Refused or unreachable, and said so on the page each time:** Reddit in every form, for the entire build, which is why no forum sentiment appears anywhere in this issue; every Iranian state site; United States Central Command; the New York Times, Bloomberg and Billboard; Wikimedia's image servers; Instagram; and Singapore's own transport-authority newsroom, which truncates at June. **Held, not printed:** American October inflation, released after we closed; Nvidia's intraday low; the victim counts at M1 and Doctor Anywhere; Christmas Wonderland's prices, for the fifth issue running.